

ble for himself”

someone has done wrong, he or she should not be spared, and punished. But now there is a tendency to hold trial by the media and some are pronouncing judgements before the investigation process is completed.

Q. What is your role in Indian cricket? Are you captain, coach, mentor or selector?

A. I'm neither captain nor coach. One must not lose sight of constitutional issues. As president-elect of the ICC, my role is clear: it's cricket promotion, but it can't be country-specific or Board-specific. As former BCCI president, I'm a member of the Board but I'm a nobody. In the IPL, I have never been anybody.

Q. What has triggered this fight—money or personality?

A. One has to credit Lalit Modi for creating a product that has been so successful. He has worked hard and taken it as a personal mission. He says he wants to show that India can. But sometimes his style comes in the way. He is aggressive by nature and often invites trouble for himself.

Q. Is this another innings in the NCP-Congress rivalry?

A. Not at all. Where is the question of any such thing? Neither me nor Praful nor Sangma are involved in the IPL.

Q. What have you advised BCCI President Shashank Manohar?

A. Basically, I have said there should be total cooperation with all the government agencies. The probe must be thorough and conclusive. The IPL Governing Council must meet and restore public confidence. The BCCI should restore the sanctity of the game.

Q. And what about Modi? Does he stay or go?

A. The BCCI and the Governing Council will meet after the finals and they will review the situation.

Q. As a third umpire, what do you think will happen? Will the IPL survive?

A. Of course, the IPL will thrive. Let the probe be completed. We will all know the truth. *Doodh ka doodh, paani ka paani.*

MANOHAR, MODI AND FORMER BCCI SECRETARY NIRANJAN SHAH DURING A PRACTICE SESSION



FOTOCORP

involved in the broadcast rights, Multi Screen Media (MSM), formerly Sony Entertainment Television, International Management Group and World Sports Group (WSG). With the carefully constructed conglomerate of big money and super celebrity under siege, the pressure was on Friends and Relatives of Modi (the FROMmies) to recant. The bids for Teams 1-8 are now being scrutinised. I-T officials went to the offices of Shah Rukh Khan's Kolkata Knight Riders and sports management group Gameplan in Kolkata, the office of Chennai Super Kings in Chennai, the Deccan Chargers Sporting Ventures in Secunderabad as well as the Kings XI office in Gurgaon.

Suddenly, Modi, the wunderkind of the cricketing establishment, has become its worst news. Floating in the fantasy of eternal immunity, he obviously didn't see it coming. Tharoor was the culmination of a series of follies which either antagonised the Government or alienated some members of BCCI, the owner of IPL. Last year, in the midst of an election, he clashed with the home minister and had to be literally turfed out of the country. (The IPL matches were eventually held in South Africa.) His style—aggressive and exhibitionist—also made some powerful enemies in India's most secretive society, which is today facing the ignominy of income tax scrutiny. In an ironical reversal of fortunes, as Tharoor wallows in victimhood, Modi, who has repeatedly been questioned by the income tax sleuths, is desperately struggling to postpone the obvious: an inglorious ejection from the

Hawala Hunt

Suspecting use of offshore entities, round-tripping and hawala, the Enforcement Directorate (ED) has put all IPL entities under the scanner. ED teams have spread across the country to seek violations of the Foreign Exchange Management Act. Sources said the IPL was under watch for over six months with strong indications of round-tripping of money, that is funds parked abroad illegally brought back. Funds seemed to have flowed from tax havens like Mauritius and the Cayman Islands in case of at least four IPL teams, part of which may have originated in India.

A strong case is believed to be building against shareholders of Rajasthan Royals—including relatives of IPL Commissioner Lalit Modi—where money had come in from Mauritius. A team was being sent to Mauritius to probe links of some individuals in certain “shell companies”. Preliminary investigations indicate that large funds were moved through certain Mauritius-based firms which were set up in 2008, the year the IPL started. The funding of team Kochi was also under the microscope. The ED was probing the source of funds of the Elite Group's Vivek Venugopal, who has a 1 per cent stake in the team. There was a possible flow of funds from Dubai but so far no concrete evidence had emerged.

by Bhavna Vij-Aurora